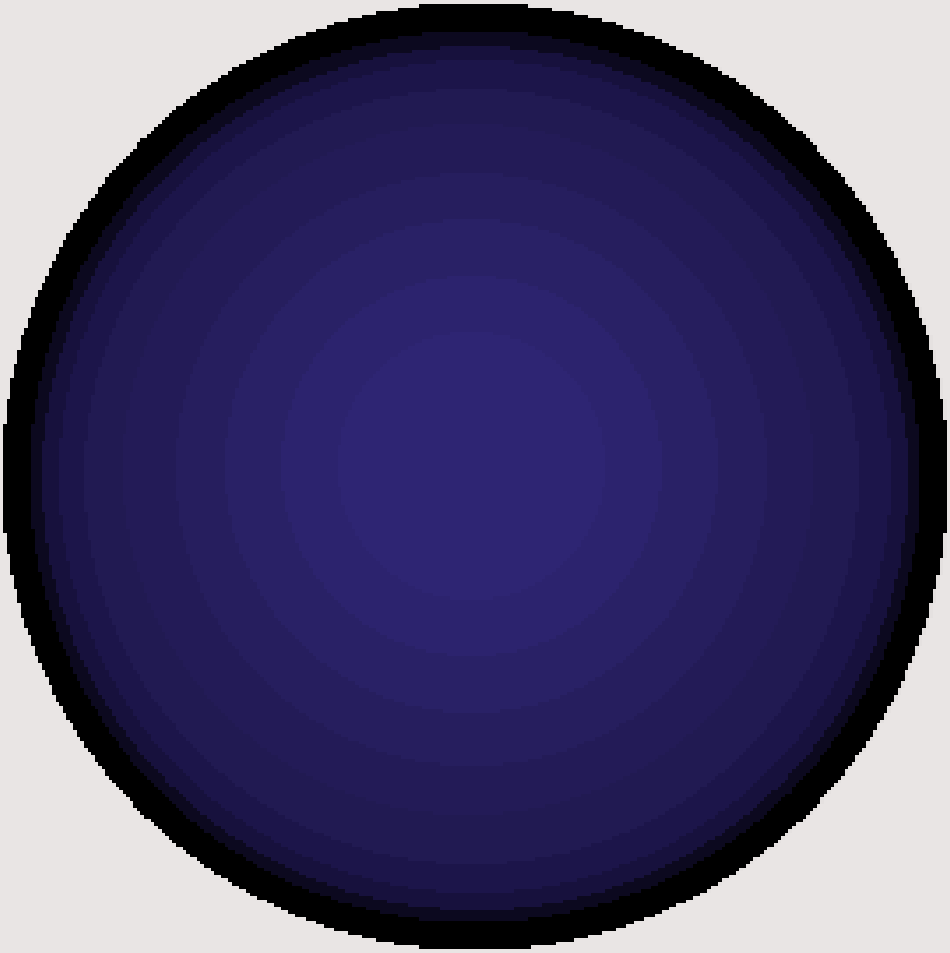
# Skies of Aetheris

## *Nebula, A Void Within*



### Chapter 1: Factions

The quiet swish of clouds hummed through the air, carrying a serene melody. Stars twinkled gently in the section of the sky claimed by the Moon faction, casting a soft glow over the land. Nebula stood watch, his gaze sweeping over his people's territory, his senses attuned to anything unharmonious stemming from the Sun faction.

Rumors had spread that a group from the Sun faction had forced their way across the star bridge—the bridge that divided their two factions, and set fire to the Moon factions buildings and homes.

A frown deepened on Nebula's face, his mismatched purple eyes narrowing as disappointment sparked within them. Why would the Sun faction provoke such unnecessary conflict? The Moon faction simply wanted to live in peace under the quiet expanse of stars, while the Sun faction basked in their rainbows, clouds, and bright skies—a sky that also stretched above the Moon's lands.

"What a look you've got on your face."

The voice snapped Nebula from his thoughts. Turning away from the polished limestone balcony, he saw Moon standing a few steps behind him, arms crossed and an amused expression flickering across his features.

"What're you thinking about?" Moon asked, moving to lean on the balcony beside Nebula.

Nebula turned his head, his eyes drifting from the Moon faction's lands to the star bridge and then to the Sun faction's bright skies beyond. "The recent reports from our faction," he murmured, his posture slumping as he rested his chin on his crossed arms.

Moon shifted his weight, leaning his elbows on the balcony and tilting his head toward Nebula. "Yes... the Sun faction's infiltration," he said quietly.

"Almost like they don't see us as equals," Moon murmured, his voice carrying a faint edge of sarcastic bitterness.

"You think?" Nebula snorted, shooting a quick glance at Moon with his mismatched eyes before letting out a deep sigh as he made his way to the exit, head clouded with thought.

Moon shifted, standing upright with a subtle smirk tugging at his lips. "Leaving to check on our faction?" he asked, his smooth voice carrying a teasing lilt. "Without me?"

Nebula paused, turning to wave a dismissive hand in Moon's direction. "And leave your *castle* unattended? Yeah, you're better off staying here." A faint grin tugged at the corners of his mouth.

"You have a point..." Moon let out a hearty laugh, his voice filling the still night air as he turned back toward the balcony.

"Now go! Go and venture out without me." He mockingly cheered Nebula on, but as the sound of laughter faded, a shadow of longing clouded his gaze. Moon's expression softened as he turned his eyes back to the stars, the weight of his thoughts hanging quietly in the thick

air.
Nebula stopped in his tracks for a brief moment, glancing over his shoulder at Moon. The elder figure stood there, solitary against the backdrop of the shimmering stars and polished stone. After a pause, Nebula gave a slight nod, as though reassuring himself, before continuing on his way.

The faint echoes of his steps faded, leaving Moon alone in the vast, quiet halls of his manor.

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Nebula treaded carefully along the fine-pebbled path, the gentle crunch beneath his boots blending with the faint whisper of the wind. A light chill brushed across his front, biting through his robes and leaving a lingering unease in its wake. He felt the weight of Moon's presence even now, far from the manor, as though his gaze still rested heavily on his back.
The night carried a quiet tension, thick and palpable. Nebula had already made his rounds, surveying the quarries where the residents toiled, speaking with his people to glean more about the Sun faction's provocations. Whispers of unrest painted the air: the Sun faction's encroachment, their disregard for boundaries, and the malicious activity spotted by the Moon faction's sentries watching the star path.
The claws of tension were raking deeper, threatening to tear the fragile peace apart...

As Nebula reached the end of the pebbled path, his eyes were drawn to a breathtaking sight—the star bridge. Though wide and sturdy, the bridge had always felt otherworldly, its luminous designs connecting two worlds at odds. He had seen it many times, but it never failed to take his breath away.
Despite its grandeur, it now seemed like a battleground waiting to erupt.
Nebula approached a nearby bench, its intricate star patterns catching the moonlight. The bench was a symbol of shared space, crafted for both Moon and Sun people to rest and converse, a relic of a time when harmony was more than just an idea. Now, with tensions rising, the bench sat abandoned, its promise of unity a quiet reminder of what was slipping further away.
Lowering himself onto the cool surface, Nebula exhaled, his mismatched eyes fixed on the bridge. The stars above seemed indifferent to the conflicts below, their light unchanging, eternal.

*Eternal...* The thought flickered in Nebula's mind. Sun and Moon were eternal, but he

and their people? They were not. They aged, lived, and died within the confines of time. If Sun and Moon had existed for so long, shouldn't peace between their factions have already been achieved many eons ago? Why were they still burdened with these relentless conflicts?
Nebula slouched on the bench, his mind tangled in questions he didn't have the answers to. He knew some things, of course—he was Moon's second in command, after all; but it wasn't enough to satisfy his spiraling thoughts.

*If tensions had boiled over before, what had the previous second in command done to quell them?* he wondered. Could he even track down that person within Moon's town? Were they still alive? Still within the grasps of Aetheria?
Shaking his head, Nebula let out a heavy sigh, as though hoping to release the weight of his thoughts with it. For now, he just wanted to savor the calm by the star bridge, fleeting as it might be, before anything else erupted.
Yet, something stirred within him—a creeping sensation, subtle but unmistakable. It felt foreign, dark, and unsettling, gnawing at the edges of his mind like an unwelcome guest.
Nebula frowned, his mismatched eyes lowering to the starry designs on the bench. He clenched his fists, trying to push the feeling away, but it lingered, stubborn and unrelenting.
He couldn't tell Moon or anyone else about the feeling. It wouldn't do any good, and he didn't want to squander Moon's blessing on something that might just be his gut or lingering anxiety.
Nebula tore his gaze from the path as the sound of a gentle swoosh cut through the air nearby, followed by the faint twinkling chime of stars. A somewhat luminous figure descended gracefully, landing as lightly as a feather in front of him.
It was Star—Sun's second in command, or apprentice, as most people referred to them.

"Star, hi." Nebula greeted plainly, unclenching his fists as he shoved the dark thoughts to the back of his mind.
Star cheerfully skipped closer and plopped down beside him, sitting just a bit too close for comfort. A soft warmth radiated from Star, and the childlike energy they carried seemed to quietly ease the tension in Nebula's chest. It baffled him—how could Sun, with their faction's rigidity and dominance, have a second in command so completely unlike them?

"You seem down, Nebula." Star said, their tone light and playful, though Nebula could sense a thread of concern woven into their words.

Nebula shook his head quickly. "No... no, I'm alright. Really."
Star tilted their head, their golden eyes catching the faint shine of the stars overhead and downcast. "Are you sure?" they asked, leaning in slightly, intense gaze seeming to peer right

through him.

Nebula forced a small smile, tilting his head back. “I’m sure. Just... thinking too much, that’s all.”

Star studied him for a moment longer before leaning back, pressing their back onto the bench. “Okay then.”

A cloud of confusion crossed his features, but he said nothing, instead turning his head to watch the star bridge twinkle like the sky above.

The silence between them wasn’t stifling, and he savored the moment. This might very well be the last pleasant encounter he had with someone from the Sun’s faction.

Circling back to his earlier thoughts, a question surfaced: was Star eternal like Sun and Moon? The thought struck him, prompting him to turn his head toward Star.

“Do you... live forever like Sun and Moon?” Nebula asked stiffly, surprised at how quickly Star turned to face him with an answer.

“No, but I probably still outlive you guys,” Star said, the childish smile never leaving his face. It was both unsettling and oddly comforting.

Nebula gave a small nod before turning his gaze back to the bridge, letting more thoughts pool in his head once more.

He felt the slight rustle of Star shuffling closer, followed by the weight of Star’s head resting against his side. Nebula stiffened at the unexpected contact, but the warmth radiating from Star was undeniable.

“—Star?” Nebula huffed, trying to keep his voice steady and suppress a stutter. He turned his head, only to find Star’s eyes closed. Had he seriously fallen asleep?

A sigh of resignation escaped his lips as he gave in to the situation, carefully shifting Star’s head onto his lap so the kid could sleep more comfortably.

His mismatched eyes drifted to Star, then looking both ways at the Star Bridge. He hadn’t meant to stay long. He was simply taking a breather from checking for information about what had happened.

Shifting slightly in his seat to get comfortable, Nebula chose to remain with Star in the meantime. Sure, he had other important matters waiting for him, but a nagging feeling whispered that they wouldn't truly matter. That unsettling sensation had returned.